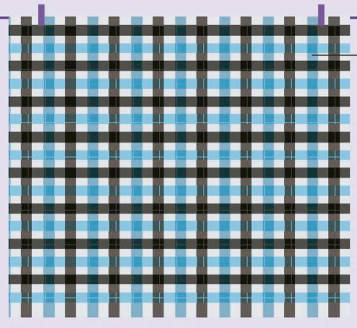
CARING FOR FABRICS

Fabrics all have different qualities and therefore have to be cared for in different ways. Most manufactured clothes contain labels giving instructions for care. These may suggest a fabric can be tumble dried, warn the owner about washing only at certain temperatures or avoiding ironing, or, in the case of a delicate fabric such as cashmere or viscose, state that it is to be dry cleaned only.



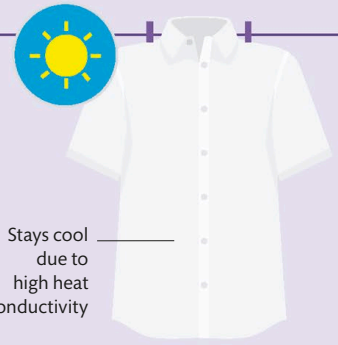
PLANT FIBERS



Rayon
Developed as an alternative to silk and made from cellulose fibers derived mostly from wood pulp, this fabric is soft and comfortable. It dyes well but weakens when wet and is prone to abrasion.



Cotton
This versatile and common fiber can be knitted or woven into a range of fabrics that are durable, comfortable to wear, and breathable. It does wrinkle easily but is simple to wash and iron.



Linen
The fibrous stem of the flax plant makes a fabric twice as strong as cotton. It is highly absorbent but dries quickly. Linen has low elasticity and creases rapidly but can be ironed easily.

New properties

New technologies can alter the properties of a synthetic or natural-fiber fabric. For example, polyester can be used to create swimwear that protects wearers from UV radiation in sunlight. Adding nanoparticles of certain substances can give fabric a new and useful attribute, such as using silver nanoparticles in sportswear and shoes to kill off the bacteria and fungi that cause the odors in sweat. Silica nanoparticles in a fabric repel stains and water by making the liquid bead and roll off more easily.



Breathability and water resistance
A membrane layer in breathable fabrics is pierced with billions of microscopic holes, which allow sweat to exit as water vapor but prevent larger water droplets from getting in.

